



FROM ZERO TO PRO - MODULE 04

Stocks, Soups & the Five Mother Sauces

Stocks, roux, and the five mother sauces are the classical backbone of most Western cooking.

Weeks 7-8 - watch, study, cook, reflect

By the end of this module

- 1 Make clear stock and understand the roux.
- 2 Produce the five mother sauces and several derivatives.
- 3 Build soups: pureed, brothy, and creamed.
- 4 Balance, season, and adjust a sauce to finish.

LESSON 4.1

Stocks: The Foundation of Flavor

Objective: Make a clear, flavorful stock from bones and aromatics.

Key points

- Start in cold water and heat slowly for a clear stock.
- Simmer gently and skim; a hard boil makes it cloudy and greasy.
- Mirepoix (onion, carrot, celery, 2:1:1) is the standard aromatic base.
- Reduce hard to make glace - intense, freezable flavor.

Technique

- 1 Combine**
Cover bones and mirepoix with cold water.
- 2 Heat slowly**
Bring up to a bare simmer, never a boil.
- 3 Skim**
Remove foam and fat as they rise to the top.
- 4 Strain**
After several hours, strain and cool quickly.

LESSON 4.2

Roux and Thickening

Objective: Cook roux to the right color and thicken liquids smoothly.

Key points

- Roux = 1:1 fat to flour by weight.
- White, blond, and brown roux: darker = more flavor but less thickening power.
- Avoid lumps: contrast temperatures and whisk constantly.
- Cook out the raw-flour taste before judging the sauce.

Technique

- 1 Melt**
Melt fat (usually butter) over medium heat.
- 2 Stir in flour**
Add equal weight of flour; stir into a smooth paste.
- 3 Cook**
Cook to the color you want, stirring.
- 4 Add liquid**
Whisk in liquid gradually and bring to a simmer to thicken.

LESSON 4.3

The Five Mother Sauces

Objective: Produce the five classical mother sauces and a derivative of each.

Key points

- Bechamel = milk + white roux.
- Veloute = white stock + blond roux; Espagnole = brown stock + brown roux + tomato.
- Tomato = tomatoes + aromatics; Hollandaise = yolk + butter + acid emulsion.
- Derivatives are small additions to a mother (e.g., mornay = bechamel + cheese).

Watch out for

- Breaking hollandaise by adding butter too fast or letting it get too hot.
- Under-seasoning a bechamel - milk sauces need salt and nutmeg.
- Skipping the cook-out so the sauce tastes of raw flour.

LESSON 4.4

Soups, Emulsions, and Rescues

Objective: Build soups, understand emulsions, and fix a broken sauce.

Key points

- Soup shapes: brothy, pureed, creamed - all begin by sweating aromatics.
- Season soups at the end and taste repeatedly as they reduce.
- Emulsions break from speed or wrong temperature.
- Rescue a break by re-emulsifying slowly into a fresh base.

Technique

- 1 Sweat**
Soften aromatics in fat without browning.
- 2 Simmer**
Add liquid and main ingredients; cook until tender.
- 3 Blend or leave**
Puree for a smooth soup, or leave brothy.
- 4 Finish**
Adjust salt and acid; enrich with cream if desired.

Practice & homework

1

Make one stock from scratch and reduce part of it to a glace.

2

Produce a bechamel and turn it into a mornay; note the ratio you used.

3

Make and rescue a deliberately 'broken' hollandaise.

Watch & learn (free)



Jacques Pepin - Techniques & More (KQED)

<https://www.youtube.com/playlist?list=PL435B8F0CB00AF764>



The Complete Pepin Archive (Jacques Pepin Foundation)

<https://jp.foundation/video-series/complete-pepin>



Brian Lagerstrom (ex-restaurant pro, approachable)

<https://www.youtube.com/@BrianLagerstrom>



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Next up - Module 05: Eggs, Dairy & Breakfast Mastery

FROM ZERO TO PRO - THE SELF-TAUGHT CHEF PROGRAM